the North Delhi Power Limited (NDPL), owned by the Delhi Vidyut Board (DVB), which supplied power to north and northwest Delhi. It was yet another vindication of Ratan's belief that there was great value in pursuing public–private partnerships, a proposal he had made in the 1983 Strategic Plan.

Engineer recalls Ratan saying that Delhi is the capital and 'we need to have a presence' here. For him, it was more a national priority than a business proposition. Soon, the technical and commercial losses faced by NDPL was brought down from 53 per cent to 8 per cent. Tata Power made the project a great success and in FY 2020 it generated nearly Rs 400 crore PAT and paid a dividend to the Delhi government. It is a showcase of public–private partnership.

But the move to be involved in the business of power distribution was fraught. Similar attempts made by the company with the Orissa government in 1999 were debacles, says Engineer.

The company also pushed 'hard to enter retail power distribution in Mumbai' by 'targeting specific business areas in the city like the Bandra Kurla business complex, the Marol Industrial Estate area and residential complexes in Malad, Versova and Kandivali for bulk sales'. While Tata Power already supplied power in bulk to large housing complexes, railways, fertilizer plants, mills and distributing companies in Mumbai, they were not in the retail business. And since this segment offered an opportunity to gain considerable brand popularity, the company decided to 'adopt a more aggressive approach in retail and begin to sell power in the suburbs of Mumbai'.

However, the plan hit a roadblock when, in July 2003, the Maharashtra Electricity Regulatory Commission (MERC) restricted the company from selling power to retail consumers, as 'Tata Power's licence issued in 1910 gave it permission to only sell bulk power of over 1,000 units and not to retail users'. But when the Electricity Act was passed in 2003, permitting power companies to 'compete for consumers' by giving them the choice to choose their supplier, Tata Power contested MERC's ban in the courts. Five years later, the company got a favourable judgment.

In 2003, Ratan reiterated that Tata Power would 'continue to pursue emerging business opportunities in the power distribution sector'. He also announced that Tata Power was formulating a strategy to generate 1500 MW for Maharashtra over the next five years. In line with Ratan's plan, that